

Statewide Baseline Report

Hope Givers Live!

FY2025-26

218 Districts · 1024 Schools · 735,894 Students



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Introduction

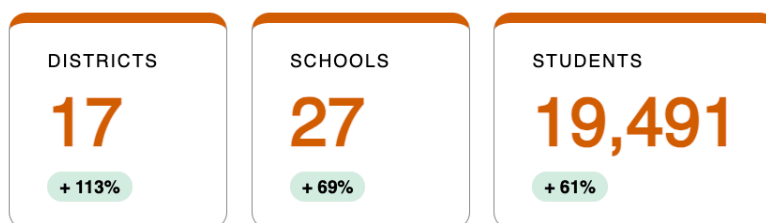
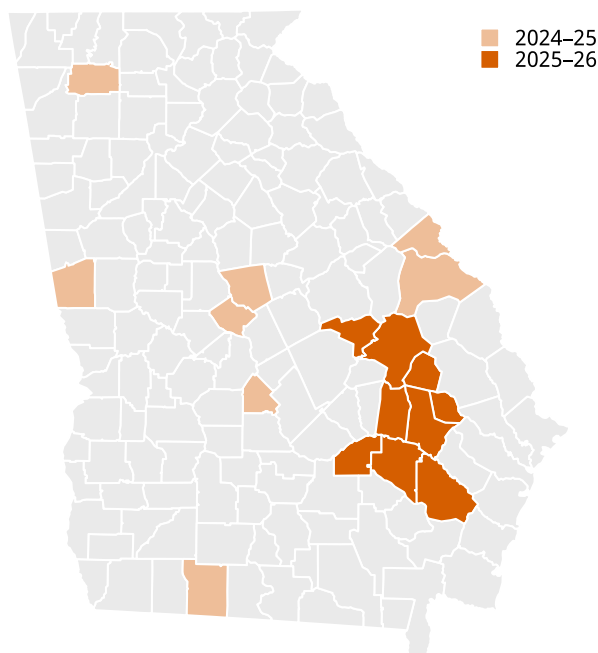
Every year, Georgia students are given an anonymous survey designed to measure school safety, student health, and school environment. In the 2024–25, **735,894 students** in grades 6–12 completed the Georgia School Climate Survey (GSCS), the new version of the Georgia School Health Survey (GSHS) given in previous years.

These measures will act as our **starting point** and we will use these insights to track progress and direct support where it is needed most.

The goal for **Hope Givers Live!** is to move the needle in all 8 domains at every participating school. After each show, schools will be given our organizational survey. We will use these baseline results alongside year-to-year program and state survey data to measure our impact and ensure our support is meaningful to every school we serve.

HGL! in Review

During the 2024–25 school year, we visited 16 schools in 8 counties, serving approximately **12,119 students** from grades 6–12. In 2025–26 school year, we have visited 11 new schools in 9 new counties, serving approximately **7,372 students** from grades 6–12 so far.



The 8 Domains of GSCS

The Georgia Student Climate Survey includes 50 questions. We divided these questions into 8 areas of investigation:

- **Teacher Impact** – The impact of teachers on student learning.
- **Classroom Culture** – Classroom environment and culture.
- **Teacher Clarity & Feedback** – How well teachers explain material, check for understanding, and provide useful feedback to students.
- **Trusted Adults** – How supported and respected students feel by the adults in their school, and their ability to ask for help.
- **School Safety** – How safe students feel in school, on the bus, and at other school activities.
- **School Environment** – Student perception of school cleanliness, organization, and upkeep.
- **Access & Resources** – How accessible and helpful students find the wellness resources, staff, and programs available to them.
- **Student Health & Wellbeing** – The experiences, stressors, and other challenges affecting the day-to-day life of students.

The scored questions are organized by domain below:

#	Survey question
Teacher Impact	
1	How many of your teachers have significantly impacted your learning?
2	How many of your teachers make learning interesting?
3	How many of your teachers create an environment where students can learn?
4	How many of your teachers have helped you set learning goals?
Classroom Culture	
5	How often do you have group discussions about what you are learning in class?
6	How many of your teachers have classroom discussions that improve your learning?
7	How many of your teachers ensure everyone is respectful during classroom discussions?
8	How many of your teachers make you feel comfortable sharing your thoughts and opinions?
Teacher Clarity & Feedback	
9	How many of your teachers give you specific feedback about the quality of your work?
10	How many of your teachers always check with students to make sure they understand instructions?
11	How many of your teachers explain new topics in a way that is easy for you to understand?
12	How many of your teachers share examples of quality work before you start an assignment?
13	How many of your teachers give you time to practice what you have learned before moving to a new topic?
14	How often do your teachers tell you what you did well?
15	How helpful is the feedback you get from your teachers?
Trusted Adults	
16	How many adults show they care about students?
17	How many adults show respect toward students?
18	How many adults do you feel comfortable going to for help?

Survey question

School Safety

- 19 How safe do you feel in the halls?
- 20 How safe do you feel in the classrooms?
- 21 How safe do you feel in the restrooms?
- 22 How safe do you feel in the lunchroom?
- 23 How safe do you feel in the gym or locker room?
- 24 If you rode the school bus this year, how safe did you feel?
- 25 How safe do you feel at extracurricular activities?
- 26 How well do you know the right steps to follow in an emergency?
- 27 How well do you know the steps to follow in case of an intruder?
- 28 How easy is it for someone to get into the building even if they are not authorized? (R)

School Environment

- 29 How clean is this school?
- 30 How proud are you of the way this school looks?
- 31 How many of your teachers keep their classrooms neat and organized?
- 32 How many things in this school are in good working condition?

Access & Resources

- 33 How easy is it to access student wellness services?
- 34 How satisfied are you with the amount of student wellness resources available?
- 35 How well do course/class offerings match your interests or goals? (MS/HS version)
- 36 How well do adults help students if they are new to the school?
- 37 How well do adults help students if they feel sad?
- 38 How well do adults help students if they are experiencing bullying?
- 39 How well do adults help students if they are dealing with substance abuse issues?

Student Health & Wellbeing

- 40 How often are you bullied? (R)
- 41 How often are you cyber-bullied? (R)
- 42 How big of a problem is bullying? (R)
- 43 How big of a problem is cyber-bullying? (R)
- 44 How big of a problem are gangs? (R)
- 45 How big of a problem is substance abuse? (R)
- 46 How big of a problem is vaping? (R)
- 47 How big of a problem is students harming themselves? (R)
- 48 How often have you been very sad? (R)
- 49 How often have you been very worried about something? (R)
- 50 How stressed are you due to school? (R)

(R) = reverse-coded item.

Source: GaDOE Georgia School Climate Survey. Questions 51-73 are informational only and not included in domain scoring.

How Scores Are Calculated

Each survey question used a 5-point response scale tailored to the question type. For example, "None of my teachers" to "All of my teachers", or "Never" to "Almost every day". All responses were converted to a numeric scale from 1 to 5.

Questions where a higher response indicates worse outcomes, such as frequency of bullying or severity of stress, were reverse-scored. This means that a 5 represents the most positive results across all questions.

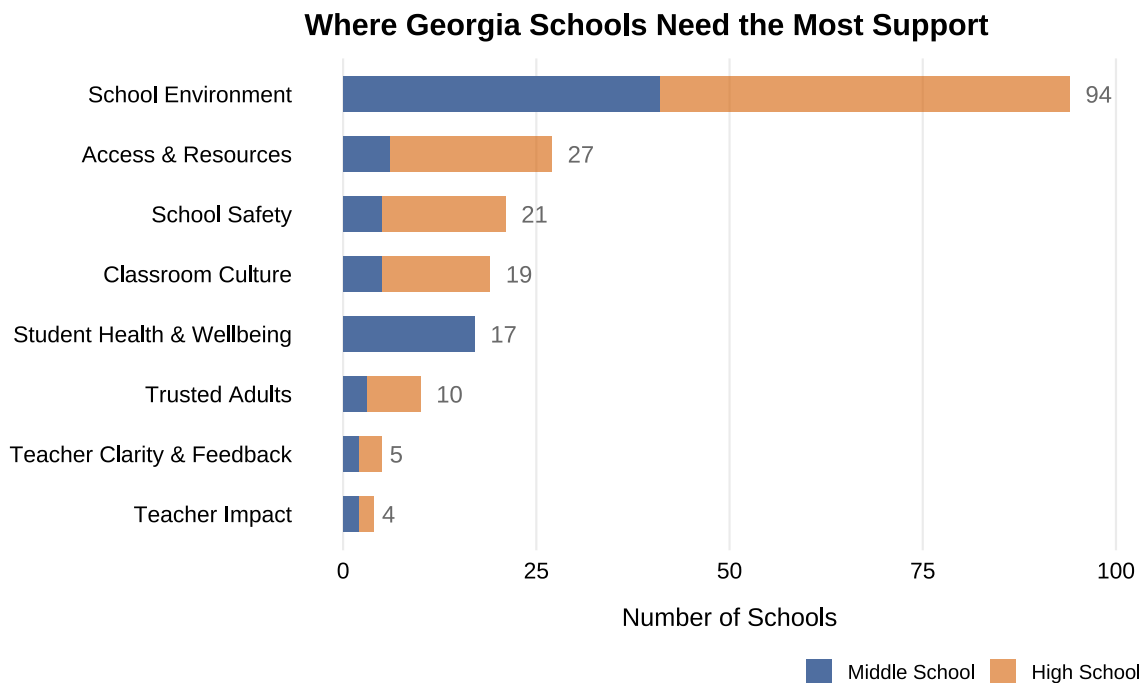
A domain score was then calculated for each student by averaging their responses across all questions in that domain, resulting in each individual yielding 8 domain scores. These individual scores were aggregated to the school and district level, weighted by enrollment size, and compared against the statewide average.

Scores represent all Georgia middle and high schools that administered the GSCS in 2024–25.

Statewide Insights

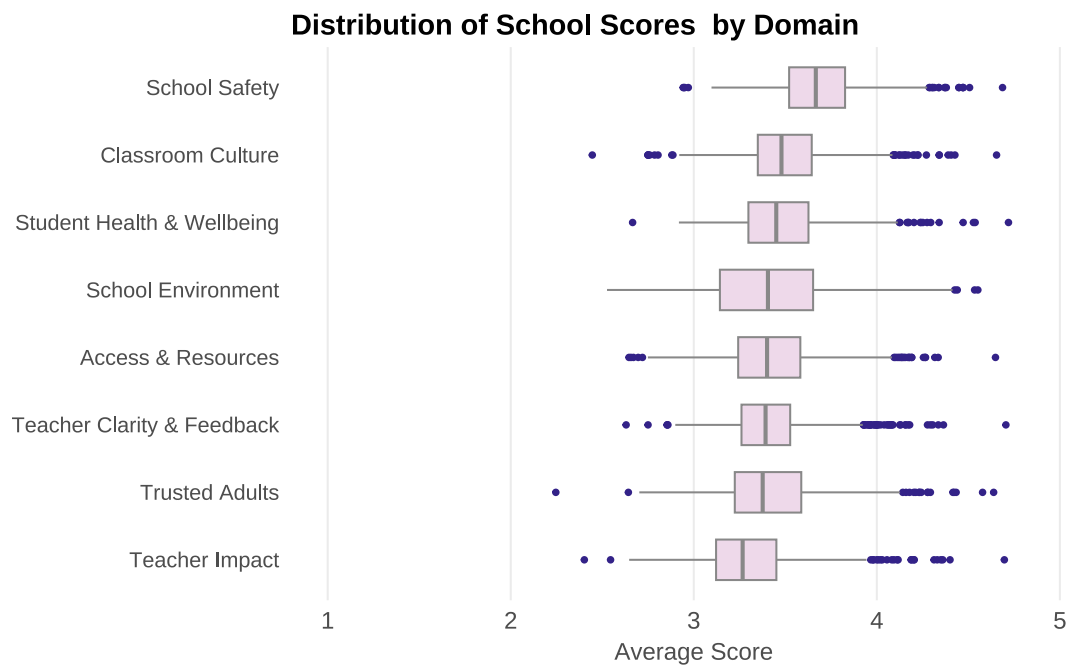
This analysis aims to establish benchmark metrics for year-over-year comparison, identify gaps in resources and student need across Georgia schools, and inform where program support can be most effectively directed.

Overview



Please note: This graph includes the number of Georgia schools scoring notably below the statewide average per domain, by school level. Notably below average indicates a score more than 0.5 standard deviations below the statewide mean. This threshold distinguishes schools with meaningful gaps from those only slightly below average.

Domain Distribution



Please note: Each box represents the middle 50% of schools. The vertical line is the median. Whiskers extend to the full range of scores.

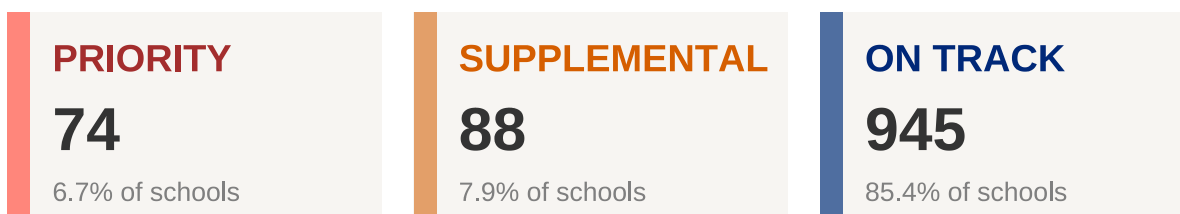
On average, the area where students felt their schools could improve the most was **Teacher Impact**. The strongest performing area across all Georgia schools, on average, was **School Safety**. The domain with the lowest outlier score was **Trusted Adults**.

How Schools Measure Up

We assigned each school to one of three tiers based on how many domains fell *meaningfully below* the Georgia state average. Meaningfully and notably below is defined as more than half a standard deviation below the statewide mean. This threshold helps us to identify gaps and direct support where it is needed most.

- **Tier 1 – Priority:** Struggling in two or more domains, or with elevated rates of self-harm or suicidal ideation among students.
- **Tier 2 – Supplemental:** Struggling in one domain.
- **Tier 3 – On Track:** Performing at or above the state average across all domains.

Tier Distribution



Total schools: 1,107. Priority = ≥ 2 domains >0.5 SD below statewide mean, or acute indicator (self-harm $>10\%$ or suicide ideation $>5\%$).
Prevalence suppressed where $n < 5$.

The tier designations above provide a high-level picture of where schools stand overall. The charts that follow look inside each tier to identify which specific domains are driving need. Understanding where Priority and Supplemental schools are struggling most informs where programs like ours will have the greatest impact.

Priority Tier

Priority — High school · n = 33			Priority — Middle school · n = 41		
1	● School Environment	61%	1	● School Environment	22%
2	● Access & Resources	55%	2	● Student Health & Wellbeing	15%
3	● School Safety	42%	3	● Classroom Culture	12%
4	● Classroom Culture	33%	4	● Access & Resources	12%
5	● Trusted Adults	18%	5	● School Safety	7%
6	● Teacher Clarity & Feedback	9%	6	● Trusted Adults	7%
7	● Teacher Impact	6%	7	● Teacher Clarity & Feedback	5%
8	● Student Health & Wellbeing	0%	8	● Teacher Impact	5%

% = share of Priority schools at that level scoring >0.5 SD below the statewide mean in that domain. A school may appear in multiple domains. Bold = HGL focus domains. Source: GCSC SY2024–25.

Supplemental Tier

Supplemental — High school · n = 42			Supplemental — Middle school · n = 46		
1	● School Environment	79%	1	● School Environment	70%
2	● Classroom Culture	7%	2	● Student Health & Wellbeing	24%
3	● Access & Resources	7%	3	● School Safety	4%
4	● School Safety	5%	4	● Access & Resources	2%
5	● Trusted Adults	2%	5	● Classroom Culture	0%
6	● Student Health & Wellbeing	0%	6	● Trusted Adults	0%
7	● Teacher Clarity & Feedback	0%	7	● Teacher Clarity & Feedback	0%
8	● Teacher Impact	0%	8	● Teacher Impact	0%

% = share of Supplemental schools at that level scoring >0.5 SD below the statewide mean in that domain. A school may appear in multiple domain. Bold = HGL focus domains. Source: GCSC SY2024–25.

Based on this break down, we can see the distribution of domains that schools in each tier scored notably below the statewide mean. The 3 domains that closely align with our program are bolded.

On Track Tier

On track — High school · n = 418				On track — Middle school · n = 527			
1	●	Student Health & Wellbeing	67%	1	●	Teacher Clarity & Feedback	74%
2	●	School Environment	54%	2	●	Teacher Impact	73%
3	●	School Safety	52%	3	●	Trusted Adults	72%
4	●	Teacher Clarity & Feedback	47%	4	●	Access & Resources	69%
5	●	Access & Resources	47%	5	●	School Safety	69%
6	●	Classroom Culture	44%	6	●	Classroom Culture	66%
7	●	Teacher Impact	44%	7	●	School Environment	60%
8	●	Trusted Adults	42%	8	●	Student Health & Wellbeing	35%

% = share of On track schools at that level scoring at or above the statewide mean in that domain. Domains ranked from strongest to weakest. Bold = HGL focus domains. Source: GCSC SY2024–25.

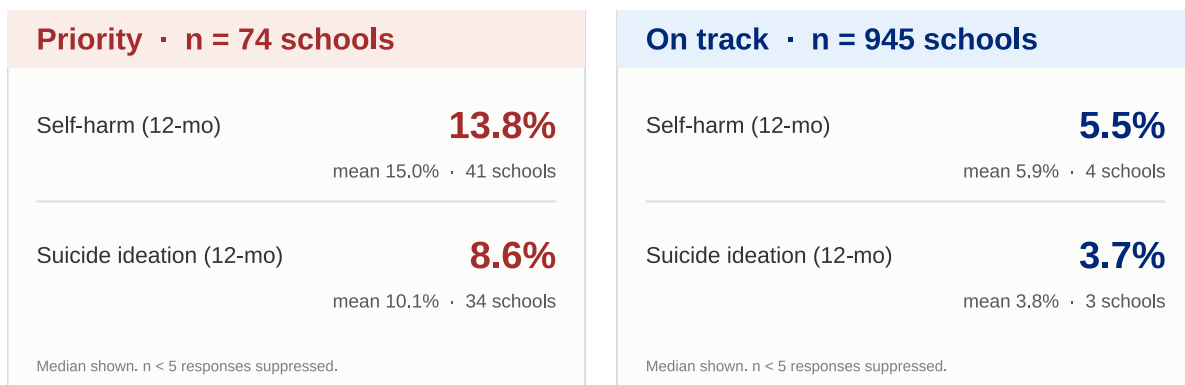
On track schools are meeting or exceeding the state average across all domains. The rankings above highlight their areas of greatest strength, showing where HGL! programming can reinforce and sustain what is already working rather than address gaps. High-performing schools remain important partners in building a culture of wellbeing and resilience statewide.

Student Health & Wellbeing Caveat

It is important to note that among schools with sufficient response data, Priority schools reported self-harm and suicidal ideation at roughly 2–3 times the rate of On track schools. These figures likely underestimate true prevalence due to this subset of questions being optional, 15.7% of completers did not respond, and schools with fewer than 5 responses were suppressed entirely.

Every student deserves to feel safe and supported at school. As part of the Georgia School Climate Survey, students were asked about their personal wellbeing over the past 12 months, including whether they had experienced thoughts of self-harm or suicide. We include these findings not to alarm, but to ensure that schools with the greatest need receive the right support.

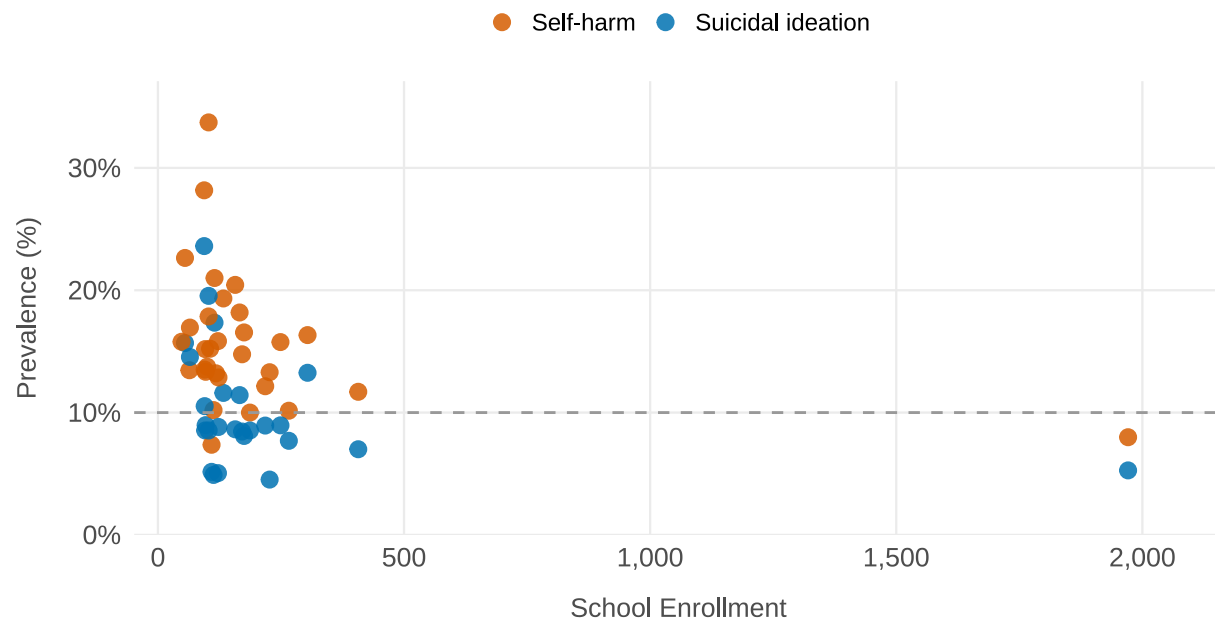
Please note: These figures reflect students' self-reported survey responses and are not clinical assessments or diagnoses. These data are intended to guide resource allocation and should be reviewed in partnership with school counselors, district mental health staff, and other trusted professionals.



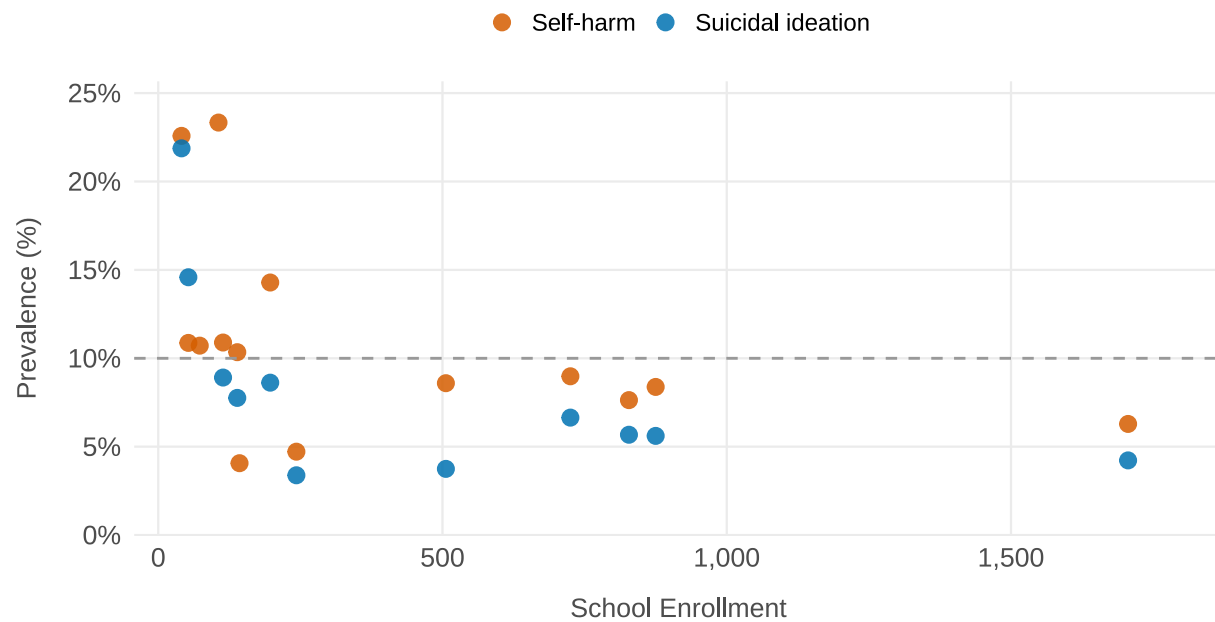
Median prevalence among schools with available data. Supplemental schools (n = 88) had no available data for either indicator. Self-harm and suicide ideation.

School-Level Prevalence

The figures below plot self-harm and suicidal ideation prevalence against school enrollment for middle and high schools separately. Each point represents one school. The pattern suggests that smaller schools, particularly those with fewer than 500 students, report disproportionately higher rates, which may reflect a combination of genuine elevated need, small-sample instability, or both. The dashed line marks the 10% threshold used to flag acute indicators in the tier system.

Middle School Reported Mental Health Concerns -- Past 12 Months

Dashed line = 10% threshold for comparison. Cells with $n < 5$ suppressed. GaDOE enrollment data (2025-26).

High School Reported Mental Health Concerns -- Past 12 Months

Dashed line = 10% threshold for comparison. Cells with $n < 5$ suppressed. GaDOE enrollment data (2025-26).

Considerations for 2026-27

The 20 districts below have the greatest concentration of Priority and Supplemental schools statewide. Mean scores for HGL's three focus domains are shown alongside school counts. District-level averages can mask variation within a district, meaning a school may be designated Priority even when its district average appears on track. These districts represent strong candidates for future Hope Givers Live! visits and expanded programming, as the number of Priority and Supplemental schools indicates meaningful unmet need regardless of the district mean.

#	District	Priority	Supplemental	HGL Focus Domain Means (1–5 scale)		
				Trusted Adults	Student Health & Wellbeing	Access & Resources
1	DeKalb County	10	14	3.28	3.38	3.24
2	Savannah-Chatham County	3	7	3.31	3.38	3.30
3	Clayton County	1	7	3.31	3.40	3.33
4	Department of Juvenile Justice	3	3	3.29	3.69	3.29
5	Fulton County	2	4	3.38	3.59	3.41
6	Richmond County	0	4	3.30	3.39	3.34
7	Rockdale County	0	4	3.21	3.32	3.22
8	Newton County	2	1	3.16	3.31	3.17
9	Douglas County	1	2	3.24	3.47	3.30
10	Muscogee County	0	3	3.41	3.38	3.50
11	Talbot County	2	0	2.85	3.40	2.89
12	Gwinnett County	1	1	3.49	3.40	3.50
13	Turner County	1	1	3.13	3.21	3.20
14	Atlanta Public Schools	0	2	3.53	3.45	3.51
15	Bibb County	0	2	3.33	3.36	3.37
16	Cobb County	0	2	3.38	3.48	3.41
17	Dougherty County	0	2	3.37	3.34	3.36
18	Henry County	0	2	3.37	3.50	3.42
19	Macon County	0	2	3.17	3.14	3.05
20	Quitman County	0	2	3.40	3.33	3.20

Districts ranked by total Priority + Supplemental schools (HS and MS). Domain means are district averages across all schools at that level. **Red** = >0.5 SD below statewide mean. Thresholds: Trusted Adults < 2.83, Student Health & Wellbeing < 3, Access & Resources < 2.9. Source: GCSC SY2024–25.

Closing Notes & Reminders

Not every student responded. Some students may have skipped questions or not participated. Results reflect the students who did respond, which may not represent all students equally.

There is not a perfect standard. A school below the Georgia average still has strengths. A school above the average still has room to grow. The goal is continuous improvement, not just meeting a benchmark.

Small schools need extra care in interpretation. Schools with fewer than 5—30 survey responses were suppressed throughout the report depending on the analysis. At these schools, just a handful of students' answers can shift results significantly, and may not represent all students' perspectives.

Self-harm and suicidal ideation data are survey estimates. These numbers come from students answering survey questions, and are not clinical diagnoses or exact counts. These insights are useful for identifying where support is most needed and should be reviewed in partnership with school counselors and district staff.